

Volunteer Notes for the Saltmarsh Bird Observatory

The Saltmarsh Bird Observatory is a converted coastguard cottage and three hides on the seaward edge of the marsh, run by volunteers since the coastguard left in 1978. These notes are for anyone who takes a shift in the cottage, a morning in a hide or a turn at the ringing table, and they assume no knowledge of birds beyond the willingness to look carefully and write down what was actually seen rather than what was hoped for, which is harder than it sounds on a grey morning.

The observatory exists to count. Everything else it does, the ringing, the visitors, the school parties and the tea, is in service of a daily log that has been kept without a break since the first spring, and the log is the reason the county, the trust and two universities take the place seriously. A volunteer who understands that will make good decisions about almost everything else, and one who does not will need these notes more than the rest of us do.

The daily log is written up at the cottage table at the end of every day by whoever was on the morning census, with the afternoon's additions read out by anyone present. It records the weather at dawn, the census counts by section, the ringing totals, anything notable, and the initials of everyone who contributed. Nothing goes in the log that was not seen; a bird heard only is entered as heard only, and a bird glimpsed is left out until somebody sees it properly.

The census route is walked every morning from the cottage door to the far hide and back, starting within an hour of sunrise, in the same direction and at the same pace whatever the weather. It is the sameness that makes the counts comparable across forty years. A volunteer who finds a rarity is welcome to stop and enjoy it, and then to finish the route at the usual pace, because the counts from the rest of the marsh matter just as much as the rarity does, and will still matter in twenty years.

Keys to the cottage and the hides are held by the keyholders named on the list by the door, and are not lent to visitors, researchers or the council, however good the reason. The far hide is left unlocked from April to September for the census walkers and locked at other times because of the storms. The cottage is never left unlocked and empty, even for the five minutes it takes to walk to the car park.

Visitors are welcome in the cottage during opening hours and in the near and middle hides at any time, and they are asked to sign the book, to keep their voices down in the hides, and to keep to the boardwalk on the marsh. A visitor who wants to photograph a bird from the boardwalk may do so; a visitor who wants to leave the boardwalk to get closer is told, pleasantly, that the boardwalk is the deal the observatory has with the birds and the trust.

Radios connect the cottage and the two nearer hides and are checked at the start of every day. The far hide has no signal of any kind, radio or telephone, which is why nobody goes there alone in winter and why the census walker signs out on the board by the door with the time they left and the time they expect to be back.

Ringing happens on the mornings the warden or a licensed ringer is present, and never otherwise. The nets are furled at the end of every session and taken down entirely if the forecast turns, because a net left up in a gale kills. Volunteers without a licence may extract birds only under direct

supervision and only after they have been shown how on at least three sessions; the warden decides when that has happened, not the volunteer, and not the volunteer's friends.

Birds are processed at the table in the order they came out of the net, ringed, aged, sexed where possible, measured and weighed, and released within minutes from the release box facing the marsh. Nothing is held for a photograph beyond the record shot the recorder takes, and a bird that shows any sign of stress is released at once with whatever data has been taken and the word stressed in the notes column.

The ringing data go into the ledger at the table in pencil, are checked against the rings used before the session closes, and are typed into the national database within the week by whoever kept the ledger. A total that does not reconcile with the rings used is investigated on the day, however late it makes everyone, because a missing ring is either a bird ringed twice or a ring lost on the marsh, and both matter to the scheme and to us.

Recoveries, which here means rings reported from elsewhere or found on birds caught here that were ringed somewhere else, are the most exciting post the observatory gets and are written up on the noticeboard the day they arrive, with a map. The oldest recovery on the board is a turnstone ringed in Greenland; the furthest is a swallow from South Africa. Volunteers are encouraged to tell visitors about both.

Nets, poles, bags and the scales live in the ringing store, which is the old coal shed, and go back there at the end of every session dry, or as dry as the day allows, with wet nets hung on the line inside rather than stuffed into their bags. A net with a hole is marked with a tag and mended on the next wet afternoon by whoever can. Bags are washed weekly in the season and hung to dry in the store.

The tide table on the store door is the ringing team's clock. Nets on the marsh edge are set only on a falling tide and furled before the flood reaches the boardwalk, and the team leader carries the table in a pocket and looks at it more often than at the birds. Two volunteers have been caught by the tide in the observatory's history, both on days when nobody was carrying the table.

Weather stops ringing before it stops anything else. Nets are not opened in rain, in a wind above force four on the marsh, or in temperatures where a bird held for five minutes would chill, and the warden's decision on the day is final. Volunteers who have driven a long way for a session that is called off are thanked and offered the census instead, which goes ahead in anything short of a gale.

Every ringer, licensed or training, signs the register at the start of the session and initials the ledger for the birds they processed. The register is what the licensing scheme audits and the observatory has never failed an audit, which is a thing the warden mentions more often than volunteers might like.

A word about the birds themselves, since the notes so far have been about the people. Everything at the table is done to the standard the licence requires and then a little more slowly than that, because a bird in the hand is the one thing on the marsh that cannot be redone. Nobody hurries a trainee, nobody talks across a bird, and nobody reaches into a bag without saying so. The recorder

keeps the time as well as the ledger, and a session that is running long is closed with birds still in the nets rather than rushed, because the nets can be emptied without the ledger and the ledger cannot be trusted without the time. Visitors who watch from the rope are told all of this, and most of them go away understanding why the table is quiet, and a few come back the next season to learn it for themselves, which is how most of the current team started.

The three hides are the near hide by the cottage, the middle hide at the sluice and the far hide on the shingle spit, and each is looked after by a named volunteer who checks it weekly, sweeps it, clears the shutters and reports anything broken. Shutters are closed at dusk by the last person out, and a shutter left open overnight in winter has twice cost the observatory a hide floor.

Sightings boards in each hide are wiped and rewritten every morning by the census walker, with the date, the state of the tide and anything worth looking for. Visitors add to them in pencil during the day and are asked to initial what they add. A board that still shows yesterday's date by mid-morning is a sign that the census was not walked, and the warden will ask why, and will want an answer.

Telescopes and binoculars in the cottage may be borrowed by visitors against a signature and a car key, and are cleaned and put away by the volunteer on the desk at closing. The big telescope on the cottage balcony is not lent and not moved; it is focused on the sluice for a reason, and the reason is written on the card beside it.

School parties come in the spring and the autumn, book in advance and bring their own adults, and are met at the car park by two volunteers who walk them in along the boardwalk with the rules explained once, kindly, before anyone reaches the marsh. The education pack is on the shelf by the desk with the risk assessment inside it, and both are read before the party arrives.

The cottage is open from ten to four in the season and at weekends in winter, staffed by one volunteer at the desk and one free to walk out to a hide with a visitor who needs help. The desk volunteer keeps the visitor book, the log and the kettle, answers the telephone, and does not leave the desk to look at a bird unless the other volunteer has come back to cover it.

Money is taken for the guidebook, the tea and the collecting box, is counted at closing by two people and banked weekly by the treasurer. The float is thirty pounds. The collecting box matters more than the sales, and the total is written on the whiteboard where every volunteer can see how the month is going.

Dogs are not allowed on the marsh at any time, on or off a lead, and the sign at the car park says so in words and pictures. A visitor who arrives with a dog is offered the cottage balcony, which has the best view of the sluice anyway, and most go away content. The rule is the trust's, not the observatory's, and the volunteers do not negotiate it.

The accident book, the first-aid kit and the throw line live by the cottage door, and the throw line goes out with anyone walking the far section in winter. The kit is checked monthly and the check signed for on the lid. Every incident, however small, goes in the book the same day with what happened and what was done about it.

The library in the cottage is a shelf of field guides, the county avifauna, forty bound years of the log and a box of reprints, and it is for use in the cottage rather than for borrowing. A volunteer who wants a book at home asks the recorder, who will usually say yes and write it in the loans book, and will usually remember. The bound logs never leave the building, because they are the only copy and the observatory has no fire safe.

The marsh itself is managed by the trust, not the observatory, and the volunteers do not cut, dig, burn or plant anything without the trust's warden asking them to. What the observatory does do is watch, and report: a blocked sluice, a fallen fence, a stranded seal, a fire on the shingle, an angler where anglers are not allowed. The report goes to the trust by telephone the same day and is written in the log.

Winter storms are the observatory's weather, and the cottage has a storm routine on a card by the door: shutters, the balcony telescope indoors, the ringing store door braced, the boardwalk closed with the chain, and the far hide checked after the storm by two people together in daylight. A storm surge in 2013 put a foot of water through the store and the routine was written the following week.

The migration seasons, late April and September into October, bring the most birds, the most visitors and the most volunteers, and the rota for those weeks is drawn up in the month before and pinned on the cottage wall. Anyone who can offer a full week in either season is asked to, because the census is worth more walked by the same eyes for seven days than by seven different pairs.

Rarities are reported to the county recorder by the warden, not by the finder, and are not put on the internet until the recorder has agreed and the trust has said whether the marsh can take the visitors. A rare bird in the far section in winter is a rare bird nobody is told about until it has gone, because the spit will not carry a crowd and the tide will not wait for one.

Photographers are welcome and are asked for the same things as everyone else: the boardwalk, quiet in the hides, and no playback of calls anywhere on the reserve. A photograph taken from the balcony is the observatory's to use in the report and the guidebook if the photographer agrees, and most do, with a credit.

The annual report is written in January by the warden and the recorder, is short, and gives the census totals by species and month, the ringing totals and recoveries, the visitor numbers, what went wrong and what is planned. It is read at the March meeting and sent to the trust, the county and the universities, and a copy goes on the shelf beside the forty before it.

Complaints are few and are about dogs, parking or a volunteer who was short with somebody on a difficult day. They go to the chair, are answered within the week, and are written in the log with the answer. A volunteer who was short with somebody is asked about it, once, and the matter is then closed.

New volunteers do three shifts alongside somebody who has been coming for years before they take a desk or a hide alone, and they walk the census with the warden at least twice before they walk it by themselves. After that they are on the list and are asked what they would like to learn; most say ringing, and most are told it takes two seasons.

The tea is free to volunteers and a pound to visitors, the biscuits are whatever the last person brought, and the kettle is the only appliance in the cottage that is never switched off at the wall. The mugs are washed by whoever drinks from them. This is written down because it was once not, and the resulting week was long.

The observatory closes for the first two weeks of January, when the cottage is cleaned, the hides are repaired, the store is emptied and dried, and the log is bound and shelved. The census is walked even then, by the warden, because forty years without a gap is a thing worth keeping.

The boat is the observatory's only vehicle, an aluminium dinghy on a trailer behind the store, and it goes out only with the warden, only on a neap tide, and only to reach the spit when the boardwalk is under water after a surge. It is not a pleasure boat and is not lent; the lifejackets hang beside it and are worn, and the outboard is run for ten minutes on the first Saturday of the month whether it is needed or not.

The committee meets in February, June and October in the cottage, and the minutes are pinned on the wall for a month and then filed. Anything that changes these notes is decided there and nowhere else, and a volunteer who thinks a rule is wrong is asked to bring it to the meeting rather than to stop keeping it.

Lastly, these notes are revised every February by the warden and each version is dated and kept on the shelf with the reports. Most of the rules here were paid for by a lost net, a flooded store, a frightened visitor or a bird that should not have died, and the notes are shorter than that list.